

Mav and the Sticky Heart of Justice

Maverick woke up on Valentine's Day morning to a sight that made him want to go back to sleep for a decade. Sitting on his nightstand was a small, plush beaver doll he had bought at a gas station years ago. The doll had button eyes, a felt tail, and was currently holding a miniature serrated knife.

"Maverick! Rise and shine! The fabric of romance is fraying, and I have found a new, physical form to sew it back together!" the doll squeaked. It was unmistakably the voice of Professor Bucktooth.

"Professor? You're a doll? You look like you're about to tell me I have a 'play-date' with destiny," Mav said, rubbing his eyes.

"I have possessed this polyester vessel to ensure that Valentine's Day is executed with structural precision! Now, grab my fuzzy tail! We are heading to **The Waffle Lodge** for an emergency inspection of 'Foundational Love!'"

Mav, feeling like he was living in a low-budget horror-comedy, carried the Bucktooth Doll to the restaurant. The place was packed with couples enjoying heart-shaped waffles. The Professor, perched on Mav's shoulder, began his interrogation.

He pointed a felt paw at a man in a booth. "CITIZEN! Why is your table devoid of floral arrangements? Do you truly believe a side of bacon is a sufficient pillar for a long-term relationship? WHERE ARE THE ROSES?!"

"Uh, it's 8:00 AM," the man stammered, looking at Maverick. "We're going to dinner later. Why is your toy talking to me?"

"A toy?! I am a licensed structural engineer of the heart!" Bucktooth shrieked. He leaped from Mav's shoulder, scuttled across the floor, and began grabbing every bottle of maple syrup in sight. "If you cannot provide flowers, you do not deserve the nectar of the maple! I am seizing this syrup for the state!"

Mav tried to stop him, but the doll was surprisingly fast. "I'm sorry! I'm not doing this! He's... he's voice-activated?"

The patrons were furious. "Hey, kid! Make your doll give back the syrup! My waffle is getting dry!"

Bucktooth ignored them. He climbed onto the counter, unscrewed three bottles of syrup, and began dousing his plush, polyester body in the sticky golden liquid. "AHA! I am becoming a

Structural Glaze! I am the bond that holds society together! I smell like a breakfast-themed forest!"

Suddenly, the front door burst open. A man in a ski mask waved a water pistol that looked suspiciously like it was filled with actual ink. "EVERYBODY STAY COOL! Hand over the cash or I'll ruin everyone's nice Valentine's shirts!"

The restaurant went silent. The waitress, a woman named Brenda who had seen everything, walked out with a pot of coffee. "Sam? Is that you?"

The robber paused, lifting his mask. "Brenda? Hey! I didn't know you worked mornings now. You look great."

"Thanks, Sam. You still doing the robbery thing? I thought you were going back to school for HVAC repair," Brenda said, smiling.

"I tried, but the ductwork was too confusing," Sam sighed. "Anyway, here's my number. Maybe we could get tacos later? If I don't get arrested?"

Mav watched, bewildered. "Are they... flirting during a hold-up?"

"DISGUSTING!" the syrup-soaked Bucktooth Doll yelled. He launched himself through the air like a sticky torpedo, landing on Sam's head. "YOUR CRIMINAL MOTIVATIONS ARE CLASHING WITH YOUR ROMANTIC ASPIRATIONS! IT'S A STRUCTURAL PARADOX!"

The Professor reached into his tiny plush pocket and pulled out a pair of **miniature pink handcuffs** he must have found in the toy aisle. With a flurry of sticky paws, he snapped one end on Sam's wrist and the other on Brenda's.

"AHA! Now you are joined by the cold, hard steel of Beaver Justice! It is the ultimate romantic gesture!" Bucktooth announced, dripping syrup onto the floor.

"Uh... thanks?" Sam said, looking at the tiny beaver doll stuck to his ear. "This is actually kind of sweet. Brenda, you want to go to the police station together? I can buy you a vending machine soda on the way?"

"Sure, Sam. It's a date," Brenda laughed.

The police arrived and took them away, still handcuffed together and looking quite happy. The restaurant cheered, though they were still annoyed about the lack of syrup.

Mav picked up the sticky, soggy Bucktooth doll by the tail. "Professor, you just handcuffed a robber to a waitress. That's not how justice works."

"It's **Romantic Justice**, Maverick! The most durable structure of all!" the doll squeaked. "Now, take me home and put me in the dryer. I am starting to attract ants, and they are very disrespectful to my whiskers."

Mav walked home, carrying a sticky doll and a lot of questions, while a faint "Toodaloo!"